

HARD QUESTIONS

*What the Original Text Actually Says — Every Major Objection Against
Jesus, the Bible, and the Gospel Answered*

*“Always be ready to give an answer to everyone who asks you a reason
concerning the hope that is in you, with humility and fear.”*

1 Peter 3:15 (WEB)

HOPE OF GLORY MINISTRY

A free book · hopeofglory.ministry

A Note on the Scriptures

Every verse is quoted from the **World English Bible (WEB)**, a public-domain translation free to read, copy, and share. Where the argument turns on original words, the Hebrew or Greek will be noted — because **the original language is the driver**. Arguments built on translations can shift when the translation shifts; arguments grounded in the original text cannot.

To the Reader

This book exists because there are questions that deserve real answers.

Not dismissals. Not slogans. Not the kind of reply that changes the subject or attacks the questioner. Real answers — grounded in the actual text of Scripture, in the original Hebrew and Greek, and in the full story the Bible tells.

The questions gathered here are the hardest ones. Many come from Muslim friends and family members — asked, often, with genuine sincerity and a deep concern that God should not be associated with partners. Some are asked by skeptics who have found what they believe are internal contradictions. Some are asked by new believers who have been challenged and have no answer ready.

The goal of this book is not to win arguments. It is to make you **ready** — to understand your own faith deeply enough that a hard question becomes an open door rather than a closed wall. The soldier of faith is not someone who suppresses doubt; it is someone who has walked through doubt to bedrock.

The method throughout is simple: **let the Bible speak**. Not the Bible clipped and rearranged to prove a point, but the Bible read in its original languages, its full context, and its whole sweep from Genesis to Revelation. The text is the authority. The original words are the driver. Let us go deep.

Chapter One — Did Jesus Claim to Be God?

"Jesus Never Said 'I Am God'"

This is the most common objection of all, and it deserves a thorough answer.

It is technically true that you will not find the sentence "I, Jesus, am God" in those exact words anywhere in the Gospels. What you find is far more significant — and far harder to explain away.

The Name That Cannot Be Borrowed

In the Torah, God reveals His personal name to Moses at the burning bush. Moses asks: "Behold, when I come to the children of Israel, and tell them, 'The God of your fathers has sent me to you,' and they ask me, 'What is his name?' What should I tell them?" And God replies:

"I AM WHO I AM... You shall tell the children of Israel this: 'I AM has sent me to you.'" — Exodus 3:13-14 (WEB)

The name *I AM* — Hebrew: *Ehyeh Asher Ehyeh* — is the self-existing name of God. No creature can say "I AM WHO I AM" because every creature has a cause outside itself. Only the uncaused Being, the One who simply *is*, can say it absolutely. In the Greek translation of the Old Testament (the Septuagint, which the New Testament writers used and quoted constantly), this name was rendered *egō eimi* — "I am." It became the divine formula: the way God identified Himself.

In the book of Isaiah, God uses this formula repeatedly as a challenge to the gods of the nations: "before me there was no God formed, neither will there be after me. I, even I, am Yahweh; and besides me there is no savior" (Isaiah 43:10-11). The Hebrew phrase *ani hu* — "I am he" — is specifically how God marks His absolute uniqueness. It appears over a dozen times in Isaiah alone, always as the divine self-identification, always contrasted with every false claim.

Jesus Uses the Absolute Formula

Now watch what Jesus does with this formula in the Gospel of John.

To a Samaritan woman at a well, when she mentions the Messiah who is coming, He says: "I am he — the one who is speaking to you" (John 4:26). In Greek: *egō eimi*. He is not merely saying "I am that person"; He is picking up the divine name.

When the disciples see Him walking on the water in the middle of the storm and are terrified, He calls out across the waves:

"But immediately Jesus spoke to them, saying, 'Cheer up! I am he! Don't be afraid.'"
— Matthew 14:27 (WEB)

Greek: *egō eimi*. In the dark of the sea, the formula God used at the burning bush is spoken by the man walking on the deep.

Then come the explosive statements in John 8. In verse 24:

"Unless you believe that I am he, you will die in your sins." — John 8:24 (WEB)

They ask who He is (John 8:25). He continues speaking about the One who sent Him. And then He says the statement that detonates the crowd:

"Most certainly, I tell you, before Abraham existed, I am." — John 8:58 (WEB)

Before Abraham existed, I am. Not "I was" — which would have been the grammatically expected claim of pre-existence. "I am" — present tense, absolute being, the divine name from the burning bush. The crowd understood exactly what He had said:

"They took up stones therefore to throw at him..." — John 8:59 (WEB)

Stoning was the penalty for blasphemy — for claiming to be God. They were not confused. They were enraged. The argument that "Jesus never claimed to be God" was not available to the people who were standing in front of Him. It is a thesis advanced by people reading translated summaries from a distance; it is not what the witnesses reported.

"I and the Father Are One"

In John 10:30, Jesus says it from a different angle:

"I and the Father are one." — John 10:30 (WEB)

Again the crowd takes up stones (John 10:31). When Jesus asks them which of His good works they are stoning Him for, they answer:

"We're not stoning you for a good work, but for blasphemy: because you, being a man, claim to be God." — John 10:33 (WEB)

There is no ambiguity in their response. His first-century Jewish audience, fluent in the Torah, understood the claim perfectly. They were not confused about Hebrew semantics or Greek grammar. They heard a man claim to be one with the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob — and they reached for stones.

Thomas at the Empty Tomb

After the resurrection, when Thomas finally sees the risen Jesus and puts his fingers into the wounds, he cries out:

"My Lord and my God!" — John 20:28 (WEB)

This is direct divine address — calling Jesus "God" to His face. And Jesus does not correct him. He does not say, "Thomas, please do not call me God — that title belongs only to the Father." He accepts the title and uses the moment to bless all who believe without seeing:

"Because you have seen me, you have believed. Blessed are those who have not seen, and have believed." — John 20:29 (WEB)

No prophet who understood the commandment against idolatry — and the disciples were Jews to the bone — would have accepted divine address without immediate and violent correction. Moses did not accept it. The angel in Revelation refused it twice (Revelation 19:10; 22:8-9). Peter refused it from Cornelius (Acts 10:25-26). Jesus receives it and blesses the man who offered it. Only one explanation fits: He is who Thomas said He was.

The Pre-Existence of Christ — Before He Was Born

A related objection says: "Jesus was a man who lived and died. He did not exist before He was born. The idea of eternal pre-existence was imported from Greek philosophy, not the Bible."

The New Testament authors — all of them Jewish, saturated in the Hebrew Scriptures — disagree on every page.

Paul, writing to the Colossians, says of Jesus:

"He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation. For by him all things were created in the heavens and on the earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or dominions or principalities or powers. All things have been created through him and for him. He is before all things, and in him all things are held together." — Colossians 1:15-17 (WEB)

All things were created through Him and for Him. He is before all things. This is not the language of a creature. This is the language of the Creator — the same One described in Genesis 1:1 ("In the beginning, God created...") now identified as the eternal Son.

Philippians 2:6-7 goes further:

"...who, existing in the form of God, didn't consider equality with God a thing to be grasped, but emptied himself, taking the form of a servant, being made in the likeness of men." — Philippians 2:6-7 (WEB)

"Existing in the form of God" — the Greek *hyparchōn en morphē Theou* — a present participle describing ongoing, prior existence in the divine mode of being. He did not become divine at the Incarnation; He was divine, and He emptied Himself of the outward expression of that glory to take on the form of a servant. Pre-existence is not an import from Greek philosophy; it is Paul's explicit claim in his earliest letters, stated as background fact, not argued as a new point.

And John, who opens his Gospel with the deliberate echo of Genesis ("In the beginning..."), closes the loop:

"All things were made through him. Without him, nothing was made that has been made." — John 1:3 (WEB)

The One who became flesh at Bethlehem was the One through whom the galaxies were spoken into existence. The Incarnation was not the beginning of the Son of God; it was the entry of the eternal Son into the story He had been writing since the first word.

Chapter Two — Jesus Had Human Limitations: Does That Disprove His Deity?

"He Went to the Bathroom. He Got Hungry. He Was Tired."

This objection is delivered with rhetorical force: *God is infinite, perfect, above all need. Jesus needed food, sleep, and rest. He was physically limited. Therefore He cannot be God.* It is an honest philosophical challenge, and it deserves an honest theological answer.

The Word Became Flesh

The Christian claim has never been "Jesus was God pretending to be a man" or "Jesus was a man who became God." The claim is more precise and more astonishing than either:

"In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God... The Word became flesh and lived among us." — John 1:1, 14 (WEB)

The eternal Son of God — who was *with* God and *was* God in the eternal beginning — entered fully into human nature. He did not merely wear a human body as a costume. He took on genuine human flesh with all its genuine limitations: hunger, fatigue, grief, and every physical need that comes with a body. When Jesus was hungry in the wilderness (Matthew 4:2), He was genuinely hungry. When He slept in the boat during the storm (Mark 4:38), He was genuinely asleep. When He wept at the tomb of Lazarus:

"Jesus wept." — John 11:35 (WEB)

Real tears. The human nature was fully human, not performed.

The question is: does taking on human nature mean abandoning divine nature? The answer of the text — and of the Church reading the text for two thousand years — is no. The eternal Son, who is by nature God, freely took on human nature. Both natures were genuinely His. Neither canceled the other. This is what Christians have always called the *Incarnation* — from the Latin *in carne*, "in flesh." God entered the experience of His own creation to rescue it from within.

"No One Knows the Hour — Not Even the Son"

One of the most quoted verses in this objection:

"But of that day or that hour no one knows — not even the angels in heaven, nor the Son, but only the Father." — Mark 13:32 (WEB)

If Jesus does not know the day of His own return, how can He be the all-knowing God?

Understanding this requires understanding the Greek word *agnoei* ("does not know") in its incarnational context. Paul describes the Son's voluntary entering of human limitation using the word *kenōsis* — "emptying" — from Philippians 2:7: the Son "emptied himself" (*heauton ekenōsen*), "taking the form of a servant, being made in the likeness of men." He did not give up His divine nature — He voluntarily limited the exercise of His divine attributes within His human experience, submitting Himself fully to the human condition, including its experience of time-bound knowledge.

This is not a contradiction of omniscience. It is the voluntary, deliberate self-limitation of the One who has authority to lay that limitation down — and who did lay it down in order to stand where we stand. As Paul writes:

"For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that, though he was rich, yet for your sakes he became poor, that you through his poverty might become rich." — 2 Corinthians 8:9 (WEB)

The poverty was chosen. The limitation was freely entered. The One who did not know the hour in His human experience is the same One who, as John describes in Revelation, holds the seven stars and opens the seven seals — the Lord of time itself.

"Show Me a Verse Where Jesus and God Were Talking"

This objection asks for evidence that Jesus and God the Father are distinct Persons who actually interact. The evidence, once looked for, is overwhelming.

At the Baptism (Matthew 3:16-17): Jesus rises from the water. The Spirit descends on Him as a dove. The Father speaks from heaven:

"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased." — Matthew 3:17 (WEB)

Three Persons, one scene. The Son being baptized, the Spirit descending, the Father speaking in audible voice. There are three Persons here, not one Person playing three roles.

In Gethsemane (Matthew 26:39): On the night of His arrest, Jesus fell on His face and prayed:

"My Father, if it is possible, let this cup pass away from me; nevertheless, not what I desire, but what you desire." — Matthew 26:39 (WEB)

A human Person speaking to a divine Person. A Son in agony asking His Father. The distinction between them is so real that it produces the most profound prayer ever uttered — genuine relational petition, genuine will, genuine submission.

The High Priestly Prayer (John 17): Jesus speaks at length to the Father in the upper room, including:

"I have glorified you on the earth. I have accomplished the work which you have given me to do. Now, Father, glorify me with your own self with the glory which I had with you before the world existed." — John 17:4-5 (WEB)

He claims the glory He shared with the Father *before the world existed* — the pre-incarnate glory of the eternal Son. He does not pray as a creature asking for something new; He asks to return to what He had before He came.

The Cry from the Cross (Matthew 27:46): In the darkest moment, bearing the weight of human sin:

"My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" — Matthew 27:46 (WEB)

Two Persons. The most costly conversation in history. He is quoting Psalm 22 — a psalm of suffering that ends in vindication. In that moment He enters the experience of separation from the Father's blessing that sin deserves — not because the relationship was broken, but because He was bearing what we owed.

"Show me a verse where Jesus and God were talking" — the answer is: *pick a Gospel and open it.*

Chapter Three — One God or Three? The Trinity vs. Monotheism

The Muslim Objection: *Shirk*

The Islamic objection to the Trinity — that it constitutes *shirk* (associating partners with God, the one unforgivable sin in Islam) — comes from a real and precious concern: the absolute oneness of God must be protected. No accusation against Christianity is taken more seriously in the Muslim world, and none deserves more careful engagement.

The answer begins with a simple clarification: the Trinity does not describe three gods. It describes one God whose inner life is richer than a simple arithmetic "1" — and the Scriptures of the Old Testament, read in their original Hebrew, already hint at this plurality before Jesus ever arrives.

Plurality Within the One God — The Hebrew Evidence

The Shema — the great confession of Jewish monotheism — says: "Hear, Israel: Yahweh is our God. Yahweh is one" (Deuteronomy 6:4). The word for "one" here is *echad* — the standard Hebrew word for "one," but one used elsewhere for *composite unity*: "the two will become one (*echad*) flesh" (Genesis 2:24) — one flesh made of two persons. "All the congregation was assembled together as one (*echad*) man" (Judges 20:1) — one assembly of many individuals.

Hebrew had another word for an absolute, indivisible singularity: *yachid*. The Shema does not use *yachid*. It uses *echad*. This does not prove the Trinity — but it removes the argument that the Hebrew Scriptures require a solitary, partless singularity in their very grammar.

Now read the Hebrew of Genesis 1:1: "In the beginning, *Elohim* created the heavens and the earth." *Elohim* is a plural noun — consistently paired throughout Genesis with *singular verbs*. This is not "gods created" (plural verb); the verb is singular. It is a plural noun used for the one God, from the first line of Scripture.

And the Spirit: "The Spirit of God (*ruach Elohim*) was hovering over the surface of the waters" (Genesis 1:2). The Spirit is present at creation, alongside God and distinct from Him — an active Person, not a force.

Then the most striking verse:

"God said, 'Let us make man in our image, after our likeness.'" — Genesis 1:26
(WEB)

Let us. Our image. Our likeness. The Hebrew is plural. This is not a royal "we" — ancient Hebrew kings never used it. It is not God speaking to angels — angels are not in the image of God and have no part in creating humanity. The best explanation the text offers is that within the one God, there is genuine personal plurality — a richness and fullness within the divine being that the creation of humanity required.

The New Testament's Revelation of the Inner Life of God

The New Testament does not add a second and third God to the first. It reveals that the one God the Hebrew Scriptures described — Father, Word/Son, and Spirit — has become fully known in history.

At the baptism of Jesus, all three Persons of the Trinity appear simultaneously: the Son in the water, the Spirit descending, the Father speaking. There is no competition, no hierarchy of divinity — three distinct Persons, one God, one act of commissioning.

The baptismal commission of Matthew 28:19 encodes the Trinity grammatically: Jesus commands baptism "in the name (*onoma* — singular) of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit." One name — not three names. One God with three Persons. The singular noun "name" is the grammar of monotheism; the three Persons named within it is the grammar of Trinitarian faith.

"Trinity" Is Not in the Bible — Does That Matter?

The word "Trinity" is not in the Bible. Neither is "Bible," "monotheism," "Incarnation," or "Rapture." These are theological summary words — shorthand for realities the text teaches in full. The question is not whether the word appears; it is whether the reality does.

The Council of Nicaea in 325 AD did not *invent* the doctrine of the Trinity. It used the philosophical vocabulary of its day (*homoousios* — "same substance") to defend against Arianism, the teaching that the Son was the first and greatest *creature* of God, created before all other things but not fully God. The Church Fathers saw that this made the Son a lesser being — not God in the fullest sense — and rejected it as incompatible with the worship the New Testament offered to Jesus and with the salvation the gospel promised: only God can save.

What the Trinity Is Not

To be precise about what Christians actually believe:

- Not three gods who cooperate (that is polytheism — what Christians have always rejected, and what the Muslim *shirk* objection rightly targets).
- Not one God who plays three roles at different times (the heresy of *modalism*, condemned by the early church).
- Not a hierarchy where the Son is a lesser being (Arianism, condemned at Nicaea).

The Trinity is: one God, eternally existing as three distinct, co-equal, co-eternal Persons — Father, Son, and Holy Spirit — who share one divine nature. Each Person is fully God, not one-third of God. The Father is not the Son; the Son is not the Spirit; they are one in being and three in Person.

The Muslim concern about *shirk* is a concern about worshipping *creatures* alongside God. Christians share this concern completely. The Son and the Spirit are not creatures elevated to divine status. They are the eternal, uncreated God — the inner life of the one God, made known in history.

Chapter Four — Has the Bible Been Changed?

The *Tahrif* Accusation

The Arabic word *tahrif* means alteration or corruption of Scripture. Many Muslims, reading certain Quranic verses (2:75; 4:46; 5:13), conclude that the Bible has been corrupted — that Christians and Jews have altered the text over the centuries until it can no longer be trusted.

This charge is one of the most serious in the Muslim-Christian conversation, and it deserves a rigorous response — both from the manuscript evidence and from the Quran's own testimony about the scriptures.

What the Manuscripts Actually Show

The Old Testament text is preserved with extraordinary care. The Masoretes — Jewish scribes working from roughly 500–1000 AD — counted every letter, word, and verse in every book of the Torah to ensure accurate transmission. When the Dead Sea Scrolls were discovered in 1947 — Hebrew manuscripts 1,000 years older than any previously known copies — scholars found that after ten centuries of copying, the text was essentially identical. The famous Isaiah Scroll from Qumran (1QIsa^a) shows a text nearly identical to the standard Hebrew Bible used today. After a thousand years of transmission, the variations are minor spelling differences.

The New Testament has the most extensively attested manuscript base of any document from the ancient world: over **5,800 Greek manuscripts**, plus thousands more in Latin, Syriac, Coptic, Armenian, and other languages — over 24,000 manuscript copies in total. Compare: Caesar's *Gallic Wars* survives in about 10 manuscripts; Homer's *Iliad* in about 1,800. When the 5,800+ Greek New Testament manuscripts are compared against one another, the variations are spelling differences, word-order variants, and occasional phrases — **no central Christian doctrine stands or falls on any textual variation**. The textual tradition is, by every standard of ancient historiography, extraordinarily stable.

What Does the Quran Actually Say About the Bible?

Here is a fact that surprises many: the Quran consistently honors the Torah and the Gospel as authoritative books revealed by God. The Quran tells Muhammad: "if you are in doubt about what We have revealed to you, then ask those who have been reading the Book before

you" (Quran 10:94). A corrupted book could not serve as confirmation or correction for God's messenger. The Quran says the Gospel was revealed "as a guide and a light" (Quran 5:46); the Torah was revealed "as a guide and a light" (Quran 5:44).

The *tahrif* verses most cited (Quran 2:75; 4:46) speak of people *misquoting* or *twisting* scripture by mouth — a charge of oral distortion by specific individuals, not a claim that the entire written text of the Bible was altered. The Quran charges some people with misrepresenting what was written — which presupposes that what was written was accurate.

The corruption hypothesis also faces a historical problem of impossible scale. The Bible was widely distributed across hundreds of cities and many different communities — Jewish, Jewish-Christian, Gentile Christian, Syrian, Egyptian, Roman, Ethiopian, Armenian — for centuries before the rise of Islam. No single authority could have coordinated a global alteration and left no trace in the 24,000+ manuscripts, or in the writings of the Church Fathers who fought each other bitterly over every theological detail. The corruption theory requires a conspiracy for which there is no evidence.

Did Paul Invent Christianity?

A related objection claims that the real Jesus was a simple Jewish teacher who never claimed to be divine, and that Paul — writing decades later, never having met Jesus in person — invented the theology of divine incarnation, atonement, and resurrection.

This thesis does not survive contact with the dates. Paul's letters are the *earliest* written documents in the New Testament. 1 Thessalonians dates to around 50 AD, within twenty years of the crucifixion. And in his earliest letters, Paul already treats Jesus as fully divine. In 1 Corinthians 8:6, written around 54 AD, Paul deliberately echoes the Shema of Deuteronomy 6:4:

*"Yet to us there is one God, the Father, from whom are all things, and we for him;
and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things, and we live through him."
— 1 Corinthians 8:6 (WEB)*

Paul places Jesus *inside* the Shema — the confession of the one God — and assigns to Jesus the role of Creator and Sustainer of all things. This is not a footnote; it is the center of his theology from his first surviving letter.

More critically, Paul explicitly grounds his gospel in eyewitness testimony. In 1 Corinthians 15:3-8, he delivers a pre-Pauline creedal formula — one he "received" (*parelabon* — formal transmission of tradition) from the Jerusalem apostles, including Peter and James:

"For I delivered to you first of all that which I also received: that Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures, and that he appeared to Cephas, then to the twelve. Then he appeared to over five hundred brothers at once, most of whom remain until now..." — 1 Corinthians 15:3-6 (WEB)

Scholars of all theological persuasions date this creed to within 2–5 years of the crucifixion, based on Paul's statement in Galatians 1:18-19 that he visited Jerusalem to meet Peter and James within three years of his conversion. Paul is the transmitter of an established tradition; he is not its inventor.

"What About Contradictions in the Gospels?"

A frequent objection: Matthew says there was one angel at the tomb; John says two (Matthew 28:2; John 20:12). Matthew says Jesus healed one blind man leaving Jericho; Luke says one man on the way *in* (Matthew 20:30; Luke 18:35). The Beatitudes are different in Matthew 5 and Luke 6. If the Gospels contradict each other, how can they be trusted?

The first thing to note is that these are **differences**, not contradictions. A contradiction is when two statements cannot both be true: "the box is empty" and "the box is full" at the same time. A difference is when two accounts report the same events with different emphases, details, or perspectives. The same event looks different from different angles; that is what eyewitnesses do.

Regarding the angels at the tomb: Matthew describes the angel who rolled back the stone (Matthew 28:2) — one dramatic figure. John describes Mary looking into the empty tomb and seeing two angels (John 20:12) — a later point in the same morning. There is no contradiction; there are two moments in the same sequence, each report focusing on different details. That is what four independent eyewitness accounts of the same event look like.

Regarding Jericho: in the ancient world, Jericho had two locations — old Jericho and new Jericho — and travelers moved between them. Luke and Matthew are not reporting the same moment; they are reporting different stops or positions in the approach.

Regarding the Beatitudes: Matthew records the Sermon on the Mount (a fixed teaching setting); Luke records a sermon on a plain (Luke 6:17). Jesus was a traveling teacher who taught the same material multiple times to different crowds — as every rabbi and preacher does. The two Beatitude accounts reflect two different occasions, not two garbled versions of one.

The deeper point: **if the Gospel writers had harmonized and polished their accounts to remove all differences, that would be the evidence of fabrication** — a single agreed narrative scrubbed of independent angles. The minor differences between the Gospels are precisely what you expect from four independent witnesses, each writing for a different audience, each emphasizing what mattered most to their readers. Those differences are a mark of authenticity, not error.

Chapter Five — The Hard God of the Old Testament

"God Commanded Genocide — the Amalekites"

This is the hardest question in the book, and it deserves the most honest treatment. God commanded Saul: "Now go and strike Amalek, and utterly destroy all that they have, and don't spare them; but kill both man and woman, infant and nursing baby, ox and sheep, camel and donkey" (1 Samuel 15:3). The word translated "utterly destroy" is the Hebrew *cherem* — consecrated destruction, devotion to death. How can the God of love command this?

Several things must be held together.

First: the context of the Amalekites. The Amalekites were not random victims of an imperial campaign. Their history began with an unprovoked attack on the most defenseless Israelites — "all who were lagging behind" when they were "faint and weary" as they left Egypt, "when they came up out of Egypt" (Deuteronomy 25:17-18). This was not warfare between armies; it was predatory ambush of the weakest. From that day forward the Amalekites appeared repeatedly as implacable enemies of Israel — predatory raiders whose consistent project was the destruction of the people through whom the Messiah was to come. The *cherem* command comes generations later, at a historical moment when the Amalekites represented an entrenched pattern of merciless destruction.

Second: the *cherem* wars were a unique, bounded divine judgment — not a standing permission. They were not Israel's general authorization to destroy whoever it wished. They applied to specific peoples at specific moments, explicitly tied to a principle God stated to Abraham: "the iniquity of the Amorites is not yet full" (Genesis 15:16). When the cup was full, judgment came. The Ninevites, given forty days by Jonah, repented and were spared entirely — *cherem* was never unconditional. Rahab, a Canaanite woman, was saved by faith in the God of Israel and became an ancestor of the Messiah (Joshua 2; Matthew 1:5; Hebrews 11:31). The divine judgment was moral, not ethnic.

Third: the same God who commanded this died for His enemies. The cross is not a contradiction of the Old Testament's justice; it is its culmination. The full weight of righteous divine judgment against sin — which the *cherem* wars executed on a national scale — fell on Jesus at the cross, on behalf of every person who had ever deserved it.

"God commends his own love toward us, in that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us." — Romans 5:8 (WEB)

"The God of the Old Testament Is Wrath; Jesus Is Love"

This contrast is not in the Scriptures. It was the position of a second-century heretic named Marcion, who argued that the God of the Old Testament and the God Jesus revealed were two different beings, and that Christians should reject the Old Testament entirely. The Church condemned Marcionite theology as a fundamental error — because it is refuted on every page of the New Testament.

Jesus cited, fulfilled, and deepened the Old Testament. He said: "Don't think that I came to destroy the law or the prophets. I didn't come to destroy, but to fulfill" (Matthew 5:17). He called the greatest commandment one from the Torah — "you shall love Yahweh your God with all your heart" (Deuteronomy 6:5 / Matthew 22:37). He identified Himself with every act of mercy — feeding the hungry, clothing the naked, visiting the prisoner (Matthew 25:35-40) — which is the prophetic tradition of the Old Testament, not a departure from it.

And the God of the Old Testament was not primarily wrathful. His first self-description to Moses, after the episode of the golden calf, is:

"Yahweh! Yahweh, a merciful and gracious God, slow to anger, and abundant in loving kindness and truth, keeping loving kindness for thousands, forgiving iniquity and disobedience and sin..." — Exodus 34:6-7 (WEB)

Slow to anger. Abundant in loving kindness. Forgiving iniquity. This is the God who drowned Pharaoh's armies — and both are true, because justice and mercy are both true. The God who would not let evil go unpunished forever is the same God who, in Jesus, chose to bear that punishment Himself. The Old Testament and the New are one continuous story, told by one God, moving always toward the cross.

"Original Sin Is Unjust — Why Punish Children for Adam?"

This objection challenges the Christian teaching of original sin: God cursed all humanity because of what one man did in a garden thousands of years ago. Is that fair?

The objection rests on a misunderstanding of what the doctrine actually says. The Christian teaching is not that God punishes newborns for Adam's personal sin as if they were guilty of an act they did not perform. It is that Adam's choice introduced a *condition* — a broken nature, a bent-toward-self orientation — that is inherited by every human being born into his line. The problem is not a charge on an external ledger; it is a corruption of the nature itself.

The evidence that this is true does not depend on accepting the Christian doctrine — it is empirically observable. Every human being who has ever lived has chosen, at some point, to do what they knew was wrong. Not once, not twice, but consistently, across every culture, every century, every level of education and privilege. The problem is not environment (though environment matters); it is something inside the human being that is bent toward the self and away from the good.

Paul puts it plainly:

"Therefore, as sin entered into the world through one man, and death through sin, so death passed to all men, because all sinned." — Romans 5:12 (WEB)

"Because all sinned" — not because Adam sinned for them, but because they each sinned themselves. Adam was the first; they were not excused from following him. The inherited nature bent toward sin results in actual sin, which results in actual guilt.

But Paul's point in Romans 5 is not to dwell on the damage; it is to announce the remedy. The same logic that explains how one man's failure spread to all is the logic that explains how one Man's obedience can be offered to all:

"For if by the trespass of the one, death reigned through the one; so much more will those who receive the abundance of grace and of the gift of righteousness reign in life through the one — Jesus Christ." — Romans 5:17 (WEB)

The mechanism of transmission — one person's act affecting all — works in both directions. Adam spread death into a family he represented; Jesus, the second Adam, offers life to everyone who will receive it. The doctrine of original sin is not the end of the story; it is the diagnosis. The gospel is the cure.

Chapter Six — Is Muhammad in the Bible?

"Deuteronomy 18 Predicts Muhammad — The Prophet Like Moses"

The passage:

"Yahweh your God will raise up to you a prophet from among you, of your brothers, like me. You shall listen to him." — Deuteronomy 18:15 (WEB)

Muslims argue this "prophet like Moses" is Muhammad, because Muhammad, like Moses, was a lawgiver who led a nation, fought battles, and died a natural death. Christians have always understood this passage to point to Jesus. The text itself gives the criteria.

"From among your brothers" — Moses is addressing Israel. "Your brothers" throughout Deuteronomy means the other Israelite tribes (see Deuteronomy 17:15: "one from among your brothers as king"). Muhammad was an Arab from the line of Ishmael — not from the Israelite brotherhood Moses addressed. Jesus was Jewish, from the tribe of Judah, born in Bethlehem, the quintessential Israelite prophet.

The similarities to Moses run deeper than biography. Moses:

- Spoke with God *face to face* (Deuteronomy 34:10)
- Led Israel through the sea — which Paul explicitly calls a "baptism" (1 Corinthians 10:2)
- Gave bread from heaven (manna) — which Jesus fulfills as "the bread of life" (John 6:35)
- Whose face shone with divine glory (Exodus 34:29) — mirrored in the Transfiguration (Matthew 17:2)
- Interceded for the people at personal cost ("if not, blot me out of your book," Exodus 32:32)
- Delivered from slavery through a sacrificial lamb (Passover — 1 Corinthians 5:7)

Jesus fulfills all of these and goes further in every case. Acts 3:22-23 makes the identification explicit: Peter, standing in Jerusalem, quotes Deuteronomy 18:15-19 and applies it directly to Jesus. Stephen does the same in Acts 7:37. These were Jewish men, fluent in the Torah, making the argument in Hebrew thought, to Jewish audiences. They were not importing a Christian invention; they were identifying the fulfillment of what Moses had written.

"The Paraclete in John 14 Is Muhammad"

Jesus promises: "I will pray to the Father, and he will give you another Counselor, that he may be with you forever — the Spirit of truth" (John 14:16-17). The Greek word is *paraklētos* — "one called alongside," helper, advocate, comforter. Some Muslims argue this was originally *periklutos* — "the praised one," the Arabic equivalent of *Ahmad* — and was changed by scribes.

Several problems stand against this argument.

First: the manuscript evidence. Among the 5,800+ Greek New Testament manuscripts, *not one* reads *periklutos*. The word *paraklētos* appears uniformly across the entire manuscript tradition, in every language and every date. The proposed *periklutos* reading exists in no manuscript; it is a hypothesis without documentary support.

Second: the text defines the Paraclete. Whatever this Counselor is, the text specifies: "he dwells with you and will be in you" (John 14:17); he will "teach you all things, and will remind you of all that I said to you" (John 14:26); and he will "convict the world about sin, about righteousness, and about judgment" (John 16:8). A spirit that *indwells* believers cannot be a human prophet born six centuries later.

Third: the timeline. Jesus tells His disciples to "stay in Jerusalem and wait" (Acts 1:4) — the Counselor is coming soon, within their experience. The Spirit arrives at Pentecost, fifty days after the resurrection (Acts 2:1-4), exactly as promised. The fulfillment of John 14 is Acts 2 — the outpouring of the Holy Spirit on the disciples, exactly when and how Jesus described.

The Test of a True Prophet — and the Evidence That Passes It

Deuteronomy 18:21-22 gives an empirical test for prophecy: "If the prophet speaks in Yahweh's name, and the thing doesn't follow, nor come to pass, that is the thing which Yahweh has not spoken." The prophet whose predictions do not come true is not speaking for God. And the prophet who predicts something in God's name that does come true has unmistakable credentials.

The Old Testament prophets who pointed to the Messiah made predictions centuries in advance with remarkable specificity:

- Born of a virgin (*almah*) — Isaiah 7:14
- Born in Bethlehem — Micah 5:2

- Entering Jerusalem on a donkey — Zechariah 9:9
- Betrayed for thirty pieces of silver — Zechariah 11:12-13
- Hands and feet pierced — Psalm 22:16
- Garments divided by lot — Psalm 22:18
- Not a bone broken — Psalm 34:20
- Buried in a rich man's tomb — Isaiah 53:9
- Not left in decay — Psalm 16:10

Every one of these predictions was fulfilled on specific, datable days in the reign of Tiberius Caesar. The Isaiah Scroll from the Dead Sea Scrolls — dated before 100 BC, before Jesus was born — contains the complete text of Isaiah 53. The prophecy was in writing before the event. The test the Torah gives, Jesus passes with a completeness that no other figure in history can match.

What the Quran's Own Titles for Jesus Actually Imply

Before leaving this chapter, it is worth pausing on a remarkable fact: the Quran itself gives Jesus titles it gives to no other prophet — titles that, examined in their original meaning, raise the question every Muslim reader deserves to sit with honestly.

The Quran calls Jesus:

Kalimatullah — "the Word of God" (Quran 4:171). The Quran says Jesus was "*his* word which he conveyed to Mary, and a spirit from him." In Arabic, *kalima* means word, speech, or command — the utterance of God. No other prophet in the Quran is called the Word of God. Moses is not the Word of God; Muhammad is not the Word of God. This title is given uniquely to Jesus. The Gospel of John opens with: "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God" (John 1:1). When a Muslim asks what Christians mean by calling Jesus the divine Word, they do not need to go only to the New Testament — the Quran itself begins that conversation.

Ruhullah — "a spirit from him" (Quran 4:171), often understood as "the Spirit of God." This is also a unique title — no other prophet bears it. In Islamic theology, the Spirit of God is not a creature; it is an expression of God's own being. The title raises a question: if Jesus is uniquely the Word and the Spirit of God, what does that tell us about His nature?

Al-Masih — "the Messiah" (Quran 3:45). The Quran uses this title for Jesus seventeen times and never explains what it means — because in its context, the word had a specific meaning inherited from the Hebrew and Jewish tradition. *Masih* is the Arabic form of the Hebrew

Mashiach — the anointed King of the line of David who would rescue Israel and reign forever (2 Samuel 7:12-16; Isaiah 9:6-7). By calling Jesus *al-Masih*, the Quran imports the full weight of the Hebrew messianic hope without explaining it.

Born of a virgin, performing miracles, sinless. The Quran records that Jesus was born without a human father (Quran 3:47), healed the blind and the lepers, raised the dead (Quran 3:49), and was described by the angel as "*zakiyyan*" — pure, clean, sinless (Quran 19:19). No other prophet in the Quran is described as sinless. Muhammad is instructed to ask forgiveness for his own sin (Quran 40:55; 48:2). Jesus alone bears the title of sinless purity.

The purpose of noting these things is not to argue from the Quran to the Christian position. It is to invite the honest reader to ask: if Jesus is uniquely the Word of God, the Spirit of God, the Messiah, born without a father, sinless, and able to raise the dead — what does that mean? The Quran gives the titles. The Gospel explains who Jesus is.

Chapter Seven — Did Jesus Die on the Cross?

"God Would Not Let a Prophet Die Like That"

The Quran declares: "They did not kill him, and they did not crucify him, but it was made to look like that to them" (Quran 4:157). Many Muslims understand this to mean that Jesus was not crucified — that God rescued Him, and a substitute or illusion took His place. It is a position held sincerely, and it deserves a careful response.

The difficulty is not merely that it contradicts the New Testament. It contradicts every non-Christian historical source that speaks of Jesus.

Non-Christian Historical Sources

Tacitus, the Roman historian, writing around 116 AD in the *Annals of Imperial Rome*, describes Christians as followers of "Christus, who had undergone the death penalty in the reign of Tiberius, by sentence of the procurator Pontius Pilate." Tacitus was openly hostile to Christianity — he called it "a destructive superstition" — yet he records the crucifixion as historical fact.

Josephus, a first-century Jewish historian writing in the *Antiquities of the Jews*, records that "Pilate, upon hearing him accused by men of the highest standing among us, had condemned him to be crucified." Even conservative scholars who dispute the extent of later Christian interpolations in this text accept the core reference to execution by crucifixion as authentic.

The Jewish Talmud records that "Yeshu was hanged on the eve of Passover" (Sanhedrin 43a) — using "hanged" as the Deuteronomy 21:22 language for crucifixion, the same usage found in the New Testament itself (Acts 5:30; Galatians 3:13).

Three independent non-Christian sources — Roman, Jewish historian, and Talmudic tradition — record the death of Jesus by crucifixion under Pontius Pilate. The denial of the crucifixion requires not merely rejecting the Gospels but overriding every contemporary non-Christian witness.

The Scandal That Proves the Story Was Not Invented

There is an argument from first principles that the crucifixion must be historically real: **no Jewish preacher inventing a messiah figure would have invented the crucifixion first.**

In first-century Jewish thought, a crucified Messiah was not a powerful claim — it was a humiliation. Deuteronomy 21:23 declared that "he who is hanged is cursed of God." To die on a Roman cross was to die under divine curse, publicly executed as a criminal in the most degrading and shameful way a person could die. Paul acknowledges this openly:

"We preach Christ crucified: a stumbling block to Jews, and foolishness to Greeks."
— 1 Corinthians 1:23 (WEB)

The disciples gained nothing by inventing a crucified Savior. It was embarrassing, not impressive. If the resurrection were a fabricated story, the natural move would have been to claim a different kind of death — a martyrdom more honorable, or better yet, no death at all. The crucifixion was reported *because it happened*, and the resurrection was proclaimed *because it happened* — and the disciples went to their deaths rather than recant.

"Why Does God Require Blood? Isn't That Primitive?"

This objection comes from different directions — from rationalists who find the idea of blood sacrifice barbaric, and from Muslims who ask: "Why can't God simply forgive? He is all-powerful. He doesn't need sacrifice."

Both questions come from the same premise: that forgiveness should be free of cost. And both miss something that the whole Bible is explaining from the first pages.

The Bible's premise is that sin has a real weight — that what humanity has done against God and against each other is not a minor accounting error that can simply be cleared with a stamp of amnesty. It is a debt, a fracture in the moral order of the universe, and a just God cannot simply pretend it did not happen.

The principle is stated early:

"For the life of the flesh is in the blood. I have given it to you on the altar to make atonement for your souls; for it is the blood that makes atonement by reason of the life." — Leviticus 17:11 (WEB)

Blood represents life — the full, irreplaceable value of a living being. When a sacrifice was offered, it was saying: *this life is laid down in the place of the life that should be forfeit*. It was not superstition; it was a language — a way of picturing, year by year, what the moral weight of human sin actually cost. The animal sacrifices were not permanent solutions (Hebrews 10:4 says explicitly that "the blood of bulls and goats" cannot take away sins) — they were visual statements of the debt, and pointers toward the One who could actually pay it.

The cross is not God demanding blood from a powerless victim; it is God, in Jesus, choosing to bear the cost Himself:

"God was in Christ reconciling the world to himself, not reckoning to them their trespasses..." — 2 Corinthians 5:19 (WEB)

God was in Christ. The Judge did not send someone else; He came Himself. He did not demand that humanity pay what it could not pay; He entered the human condition and paid it from within. This is not primitive ritual; it is the most sophisticated act of justice and love in the history of the universe — love that was not sentimental enough to ignore the debt, and justice that was not cold enough to let humanity bear it alone.

The question "why does God need blood?" misunderstands the grammar of the transaction. God did not *need* sacrifice; He provided it. "God will provide the lamb for himself" — Abraham said it over his son at Moriah (Genesis 22:8), and he said it before the ram appeared in the thicket, as if he already knew. And God did provide the Lamb. The cross was not weakness; it was the lamb in the thicket, finally, for the whole world.

Isaiah 53 — Written 700 Years Before the Event

The deepest answer to "why would God let His prophet die like that?" is that this death was the plan the whole Bible was building toward.

Isaiah 53, written seven hundred years before the crucifixion — and preserved verbatim in the Dead Sea Scrolls dated before 100 BC — describes the suffering Servant:

"He was despised and rejected by men, a man of suffering and acquainted with disease... Surely he has borne our sickness and carried our suffering... He was wounded for our transgressions. He was crushed for our iniquities. The punishment that brought our peace was on him; and by his wounds we are healed. All we like sheep have gone astray. Everyone has turned to his own way; and Yahweh has laid on him the iniquity of us all." — Isaiah 53:3-6 (WEB)

Not a defeat. Not a mistake. Not a rescue that arrived too late. A plan — a substitution of breathtaking scope — written into the script seven centuries before the curtain rose.

"He humbled himself, becoming obedient to the point of death — yes, the death of the cross. Therefore God also highly exalted him and gave him the name which is above every name; that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of those in heaven, those on earth, and those under the earth." — Philippians 2:8-10 (WEB)

The cross was the appointed place where justice and mercy met. The cup that humanity had earned by its rebellion against God — Jesus drank it, so that the cup of salvation could be offered to anyone who will receive it.

"Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" — John 1:29
(WEB)

Conclusion — For the Soldier of Faith

What to Do with These Answers

You now have real answers to the hardest and most common objections raised against the Christian faith. Not every conversation will go the way you plan. Your interlocutor may not be seeking — they may be trying to score a point. They may have memorized counter-arguments for each of these answers. They may not receive what you offer.

That is not your problem to solve. Your calling is to be ready, to speak the truth, and to leave the work of conviction to the One who does it:

"For the word of God is living and active, and sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing even to the dividing of soul and spirit, of both joints and marrow, and is able to discern the thoughts and intentions of the heart." — Hebrews 4:12 (WEB)

The sword is already sharp. Your job is to wield it honestly and set it down knowing that the harvest belongs to God.

Stay in the Original

The single most important discipline in this book is the one that runs through every chapter: *stay in the original*. The Greek *egō eimi* is not the same as the English "I am," which is a commonplace verb. The Hebrew *echad* versus *yachid* is not an argument available in any translation. *Hilastērion* — mercy seat — is invisible if you do not know Exodus 25. The Greek *paraklētos* versus the proposed *periklutos* is a manuscript question, not a translation question.

The soldier of faith who knows the original languages is not performing scholarship for academics. They are a laborer using the right tools. Arguments built on translations can be answered at the translation level; arguments grounded in the original text cannot be moved by appealing to a different translation. Get to the ground. Stay there.

For the One Asking the Questions

If you are reading this book not to be equipped but because *you* are the one with the questions — welcome. All of these objections were honest ones at some point, asked by people who genuinely wanted to know whether Jesus is who He said He is.

The invitation of the entire Bible is the same from Genesis to Revelation:

"Come now, and let's reason together,' says Yahweh." — Isaiah 1:18 (WEB)

God does not ask for blind faith. He asks for the faith of a person who has looked honestly at the evidence and is willing to follow the light they find. If you have followed this book through seven chapters of hard questions and honest answers — you have looked. What happens next is between you and the One the book is about.

He is not hiding. The evidence for His claim is written in the manuscripts, in the prophecies, in the original languages, in the witness of hostile historians, in the seal of the resurrection. And the door He opened at the cross is still open.

"Whoever comes to me I will in no way throw out." — John 6:37 (WEB)

Appendix — Quick-Reference: The Hardest Questions and Where the Answers Live

Objection	Key Text	Original Word/Concept
"Jesus never said 'I am God'"	John 8:58; John 10:33; John 20:28	<i>egō eimi</i> — the divine I AM from Exodus 3:14
"Jesus didn't know things — not omniscient"	Mark 13:32; Philippians 2:7	<i>kenōsis</i> — voluntary limitation in the Incarnation
"Show me Jesus and God talking"	Matthew 3:17; Matthew 26:39; John 17:1-5	The baptism, Gethsemane, the High Priestly Prayer
"God is one — Trinity is three gods"	Genesis 1:26; Deuteronomy 6:4; Matthew 28:19	<i>echad</i> (composite one); one <i>name</i> , three Persons
"Trinity was invented at Nicaea"	1 Corinthians 8:6; 2 Corinthians 13:14	Nicaea defended the apostolic faith, not invented it
"Bible has been corrupted"	Dead Sea Scrolls; 5,800+ Greek manuscripts	<i>tahrif</i> — Quran itself honors the Bible as revelation
"Paul invented Christianity"	1 Corinthians 15:3-8; Galatians 1:18-19	Pre-Pauline creed within 2–5 years of the crucifixion
"God commanded genocide — Amalekites"	Genesis 15:16; 1 Samuel 15:3; Romans 5:8	<i>cherem</i> — bounded divine judgment, not racial policy
"OT God is wrath, Jesus is love"	Exodus 34:6-7; Matthew 5:17	One God: the cross is where justice and mercy meet
"Deuteronomy 18 predicts Muhammad"	Deuteronomy 18:15; Acts 3:22; Acts 7:37	"From your brothers" = Israelite; Jesus fulfills every point
"John 14 Paraclete = Muhammad"	John 14:16-17; Acts 2:1-4	No manuscript reads <i>periklutos</i> ; Spirit indwells, not arrives in 600 years
"Jesus didn't die on the cross"	Isaiah 53:3-6; 1 Corinthians 1:23; Tacitus	Three non-Christian sources; crucifixion was a scandal, not an invention

About this book

Hard Questions is published freely by **Hope of Glory Ministry**, that the earth may be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord. It may be read, shared, and given away without charge. All Scripture is from the World English Bible (public domain). We hold the historic

Nicene faith and the plain reading of Scripture; we compare beliefs and never demean persons.

To go further, or to ask any question, visit Hope of Glory Ministry — Ask Hope, open The Scroll, or read the Gospel of John slowly. The gospel is free.

"For the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of Yahweh, as the waters cover the sea." — Habakkuk 2:14 (WEB)